The Pundit could not check himself from bursting into a loud **guffaw** at the woman's **naivety**.

Days passed. The period of the Pundit's vow came to an end. He told the milkmaid, "Moti, I must say that you have served me ever well. I appreciate the pain you took in getting up in the small hours and milking the cow and delivering the milk to me at **dawn**. I bless you!"

Moti bowed to him. "So, sir, from tomorrow I report as before, soon after the sunrise; is that all right?"

"Fine," said the Pundit. And then he remembered the boatman. "Moti!" he said, "Tell the boatman how pleased I am with him."

"But, sir, I never bothered him, knowing that he could not come that early!" said Moti.

"Who then plied the boat for you?"

"Boat? Why Sir? I did not need any boat!"

"How then did you cross the river?"

"Good God!" muttered Moti. "You, who can remember hundreds of pages of scriptures, forgot the secret you passed on to me the other day?"

"What do you mean?" asked the Pundit, **intrigued**.

"I just utter the name of Vishnu and walk across the river!

The water remains ankle-deep for me!"

"Ankle-Deep? But isn't the river in spate? Isn't it fact that even in the hottest summer there is enough water in the river for boats to ply?" asked the Pundit.

"But I apply the secret!" Moti was surprised that the Pundit had totally forgotten his own secret formula.

"I see!"

"So, now you remembered !" said Moti feeling happy. "From tomorrow I will take recourse to the boat. Let me apply the secret for the last time while returning today."

Moti stepped out onto the road. It was a foggy dawn. No doubt the woman was kidding him – concluded the Pundit and then followed her tiptoe.

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